Ola's AI help desk: kill, narrow or keep?

Internal memo | From: Pranav Thatavarti, PM, Rider Experience | To: Ola Consumer leadership | 20 October 2026 | Decision needed this month

Portfolio exercise. I don't work at Ola. Public facts carry a source number. Review numbers are from my own analysis of Play Store reviews [5]. Anything else is my estimate, marked (est.).

> **My call: kill and replace.** Retire the help bot as the only door for fare problems. Point the AI at the fare itself: a "Driver asked for more" button, an AI that can approve a refund within a day, and a person who is the only one allowed to say no.

Context

I set out to kill Kruti, Krutrim's AI assistant. Ola got there first. Kruti launched on 12 June 2025 to book cabs and order food by voice or text in 13 Indian languages [2]. By 16 April 2026 it was gone from both app stores and from inside the Ola app [3], after fewer than 500,000 downloads [4]. Today's Play Store listing doesn't mention AI at all [6].

What's left in the ride app is the AI help desk. Ola said in August 2024 that Krutrim's AI customer care tool was live in Ola Cabs [1]. I can't see which model runs it today, but riders describe a bot, FAQs and no person [5]. Meanwhile FY25 revenue fell 42% to ₹1,171 crore and the loss doubled to ₹662 crore [7].

What we bet on vs what the data shows

What we bet on	What the data shows
Indian-language AI is our edge. Voice in 13 languages [2] is a real need for riders who don't type English.	Fair bet, wrong door. Kruti lasted 10 months [3]. In my 3,000 sampled Ola reviews, none mention Kruti and one mentions Krutrim, about maps [5]. Caveat: my sample is English only, so it misses the riders Kruti was for.
An AI help desk holds support costs down while revenue falls [1][7].	"Support unreachable" is 6.3% of Ola reviews, vs 2.4% on Uber and 2.8% on Rapido [5]. Twelve name the bot, FAQs or auto-replies outright: "In need we are forced to chat with AI."
Most tickets are simple, so FAQs can deflect them.	Our #1 ticket isn't simple. Fare shown vs fare charged is 14.5% of Ola reviews, vs 6.6% on Uber [5]. 9.2% are a driver asking for more than the app fare after accepting; 238 of those 277 are 1 star [5]. That needs money moved, not an article.
Deflection is a saving.	It moves the cost somewhere worse. 26% of Ola fare complaints also say they couldn't get help (keyword count) [5]. The regulator has acted once: 2,061 complaints in 2024, led by fares higher than shown and drivers asking for cash [8].

Options considered

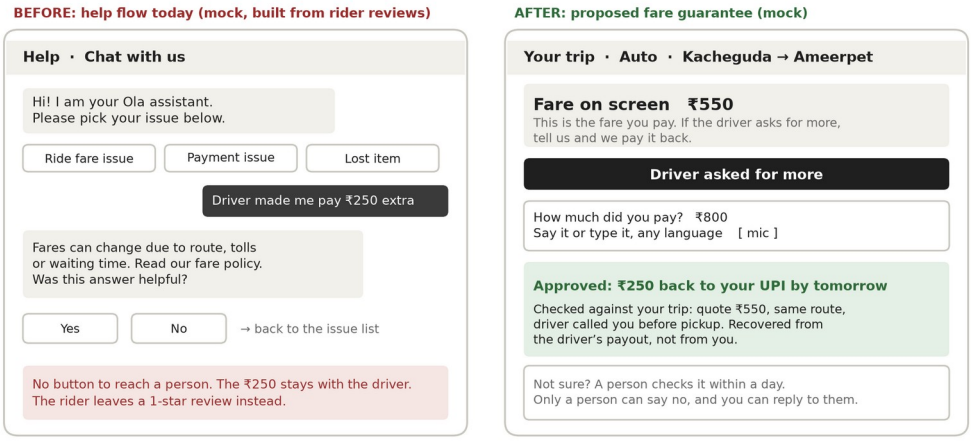
Option	What it means	Cost and risk
Kill	Switch the bot off. Every ticket goes to a human chat or call.	Most expensive. Employee costs fell 39% in FY25 [7] and that headcount isn't coming back. Queues just move.
Narrow	Keep the bot for receipts and lost items. Add "talk to a person" for money issues.	Cheap. But people get flooded with the same fare fights and refunds still take days.
Keep	Leave it and tune the FAQs.	No build cost. Riders keep leaving, and the 2024 CCPA findings can repeat [8].
Kill and replace (my pick)	Retire the bot as the door for money problems. Ship a fare guarantee with AI refunds and a person behind every no.	One squad for a quarter (est.). Refunds paid first, recovered from driver payouts. Risks: fewer accepted short trips, refund abuse.

Recommendation

Kill and replace. The bot isn't the villain. It's pointed at the wrong job. It answers questions, and our riders don't have questions. They have ₹250 a driver took. An AI that says "yes, here's your money" fixes that. One that says "read our fare policy" makes it worse. I'd keep Krutrim's best work, Indian-language voice, so a rider can report in Telugu by voice note.

What replaces it

- **The rule:** the fare on screen is the fare you pay. Accepting a trip means accepting that fare.
- **One button,** "Driver asked for more", live from acceptance until 24 hours after the trip. No cancel fee if you cancel over it.
- **AI triage** reads the report (text or voice; Hindi, Telugu or English) next to trip data: quote, route, a driver call before pickup, a switch to cash. Clear cases get paid to UPI within a day, up to a cap (est. ₹300 a trip).
- **AI can approve. Only a person can deny,** and the rider can reply to that person. Same rule I use in my claims work. A simple model flags repeat drivers for ops. No call recording. The bot stays for receipts and lost items.



Mock screens. Left: today's flow as riders describe it in reviews [5]. Right: the proposed trip screen. Amounts echo a real Hyderabad review from Kacheguda station: ₹550 shown, ₹800 demanded [5].

How I'd measure it

Metric	Baseline	Target
Share of Ola reviews: driver asked for more	9.2% [5]	4.6% in two quarters (est.)
Share of Ola reviews: support unreachable	6.3% [5]	Under 3%, Rapido's level (est.)
Median time from report to refund	Not public	Under 24 hours (est.)
Guardrails: short-trip acceptance; wrong approvals in audit	Internal; none yet	Max 2-point drop; under 5% (est.)

What would change my mind

- Trip logs show “asked for more” is rare per 1,000 trips and reviews blow it up. My evidence is reviews, not trips.
- Hindi and Telugu reviews, which my English sample misses, show the current bot works for those riders.
- Drivers stop accepting short trips at the app fare. Then the fare is too low, and I'd fix pricing before policing.

Rollout and comms

Who	What we say	When and how
Drivers	Accepting means the app fare. Extra collected comes back out of payout after a check. You can appeal to a person.	Week −2. Hub briefings in Telugu, Hindi and English.
Support ops	New queue. Only people deny, with a reason the rider sees.	Week −1. Training, audit rubric.
Riders	“The fare on screen is the fare you pay.” No AI in the headline.	Week 0. Trip screen, push in the test city.
Press, regulator	Refunds go to your bank or UPI within a day, not coupons [8].	Holding line, only if asked.

How I'd test this before killing anything

- **Where:** Hyderabad autos and bikes, six weeks (est.). Riders split 50/50: test riders get the button and AI refunds, the holdout keeps today's bot.
- **Primary metric:** rides per rider in the 30 days after a fare dispute, test vs holdout. Also reports per 1,000 trips and time to refund.
- **Stop early** if driver acceptance on short trips drops over 2 points or audited wrong approvals pass 5% (est.).
- **Decision rule:** disputed test riders ride 10%+ more (est.) with guardrails intact, so the bot stops being the money door everywhere.

Sources

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[6] Ola app on Google Play, read 20 Oct 2026 (v7.5.9, updated 9 Oct 2026). https://play.google.com/store/apps/details?id=com.olacabs.customer

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